tourist spots. Its smaller size led to it being equated with a 'pony', robbing it of a distinct identity. By 2007, the Bhimthadi had made an appearance in the 'critical breeds' list of the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) of the United Nations. Official estimates put their number at just over 5,100 and dwindling in their areas of breeding in the Deccan plateau—a marginal presence in India's total equine (including horses, ponies, donkeys and mules) population of 550,000.

However, the end of last year spelt a new beginning for the half-forgotten equine. In December 2023, the Breed Registration Committee of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) recognised the Bhimthadi horse as an independent breed. The recognition, it is hoped, will spur the breeding and conservation of the horse for use in equestrian sports like polo and for endurance training. Improved breeding practices could also lead to higher numbers and better quality.



"With reduced use, Bhimthadi horse numbers are falling. If we do not preserve them, they will fade away"

–RANJEET PAWAR
Founder, All India Bhimthadi Horse Association

The Battle for Revival

Playing an instrumental role in this effort has been Ranjeet Pawar, founder of the All India Bhimthadi Horse Association and owner of Baramati Ashwa Paga, a stud farm that lies around 100



MANDAR DEODHAR

SYMPHONY IN CANTER A pair of Bhimthadi horses in a stud farm near Pune